

seemed to be discovering the power of intent in the second half of the 2025 season. However, CSK faced the question of where to place its latest recruit in a batting order already filled with exciting talents.

Prior to the World Cup, number three would have been a tempting option for Samson, given that it is the position he batted at most frequently for Rajasthan Royals and his propensity for taking down spin. However, post his World Cup exploits, it seems almost inconceivable that Samson will be anywhere other than at the top of the order, with the express charge of setting the tone at the outset.

Kolkata Knight Riders will likely have taken similar lessons. The three-time champion endured a tough 2025 season, often struggling due to a lack of ballast with the bat. While the arrival of Cameron Green is expected to partially solve this, it still faces questions about how it will structure the rest of its batting.

Its options include keeping Sunil Narine at the top of the order and playing Rovman Powell to add heft to the middle order, but what seems likely is that at least one of its blazing Kiwi openers, Finn Allen and Tim Seifert, will start the tournament given their stunning campaign (a collective 624 runs at a 180.86 strike-rate), where they showed a penchant for providing fast starts.

With the ball, Rajasthan Royals' bowling attack seems structured towards taking wickets with the new ball, particularly with trump card Jofra

Archer. Archer had mixed returns for England but was at his best with the new ball in hand, taking eight wickets at 20.37 and often bowling three overs in his first spell to create early incisions.

Getting creative

The Royals are also among the teams that could use the World Cup as inspiration to rethink player roles. It has generally used Shimron Hetmyer as a finisher, but the Guyanese batter shone at number three for West Indies, proving especially effective at taking down spin through the middle of the innings and pushing the scoring rate up in a team with

Rapid fire: KKR's Finn Allen and Tim Seifert showcased a clear penchant for fast starts while opening for New Zealand at the T20 World Cup.

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relatively calculated openers.

Moving Hetmyer up the order thus becomes tempting for the Royals, albeit it may be tempered by the pre-existing logjam and the proliferation of left-handers at the top.

Similarly, Mumbai Indians would have been buoyed by the form of Tilak Varma and Will Jacks. Both batters have previously been part of a race for top-order spots, but both showcased their versatility lower down the order.

Tilak emerged as an adept pace-hitter at the end of innings, while Jacks (a reasonable candidate for Player of the Tournament) became England's designated crisis man and finisher.

Who wins the space race?

Where a World Cup features a wide distribution of talent between its competing teams, the IPL has a far more even spread of quality, with every team capable of stunning highs on its day.

In such a competitive field, success becomes defined by which team can maximise its resources — and assemble enough to take the extra step required to be champion.

The T20 World Cup thus becomes a cauldron of ideas, a source of inspiration for franchises to see how they can get the best out of their players and, cumulatively, chart a path to becoming the next IPL champion.

